LONG LIVE FILM:
CELEBRATING 75 YEARS OF THE BFI NATIONAL ARCHIVE

29 April 2010 **10/29**

This July and August, the world's largest and most significant collection of film and television, the BFI National Archive, marks its 75th anniversary with a two-month celebration of film seasons, nationwide releases and special events, with highlights including:

Dangerous Beauty: The Joy of Nitrate Film
A rare opportunity to savour the delights of original nitrate prints on the big screen for the first time in ten years

BFI Most Wanted
A national campaign to find 75 'Lost' films and a look at some of the BFI National Archive's recent discoveries

Alberto Cavalcanti
A landmark retrospective of a much-loved director famed for his work at the GPO Film Unit and Ealing studios, and nationwide theatrical release of ***Went the Day Well?*** (1942) and ***They Made Me a Fugitive*** (1947) – newly restored by the BFI National Archive

SUPPORT THE BFI
A nationwide campaign to rescue nine of **Hitchcock**'s classic films, announced on the 30th anniversary of his death

Special screening at BRASS: Durham International Festival
Experimental artist and filmmaker **Bill Morrison** sets archival footage to a new score by internationally acclaimed Icelandic musician and composer **Jóhann Jóhannsson**, with their new collaborations ***The Miners' Hymns***

DANGEROUS BEAUTY: THE JOY OF NITRATE FILM

Britain's only public cinema with a licence to show nitrate film, **BFI Southbank**, will screen very rarely seen nitrate prints from the BFI National Archive in July and August. This is an unmissable opportunity to enjoy the unique quality of nitrate film on a big screen. Thanks to its high silver content, nitrate film in black and white has a wonderful lustre, while the vibrant colour of an original dye transfer Technicolor nitrate print is unforgettable. The intensity of the projected film experience is impossible to reproduce by any other means. The BFI National Archive contains what we believe are among the world's largest holdings of nitrate film (in excess of 180,000 cans).

From 1895 to 1952, films were shot on cellulose nitrate stock, which can be highly flammable and subject to drastic deterioration. These incendiary properties have inflamed the imaginations of filmmakers as varied as Giuseppe Tornatore and Quentin Tarantino. Archives the world over have tried, sometimes in vain, to preserve this fragile medium which can crumble away into dust. The survival of nitrate prints and negatives continues to be essential in this digital age – the recent restoration of ***The Red Shoes*** (1948) depended on original nitrate negatives held by the BFI National Archive.

In July and August there will a chance to view eight original nitrate screenings, including **John Boulting**'s classic gangster film ***Brighton Rock*** (1947), adapted by Graham Greene from his own novel and starring **Richard Attenborough** as a 'ruthless, hollow-eyed psychopath'; ***The Yearling*** (1946), starring Gregory Peck and Jane Wyman in luscious Technicolor; and ***Volga-Volga*** (1938), Soviet musical comedy centred around a group of amateur performers on their way to a talent contest in Moscow – allegedly Stalin's favourite film.

THE HUNT FOR THE BFI MOST WANTED

According to the Film Foundation's website, more than half of all American films produced before 1950 have disappeared. In July, the BFI launches a hunt for its **75 Most Wanted** films, posting a special list of the 'missing' titles online, along with some clues as to what they looked like and as much contextual information as we can find using contemporary reviews, scripts, stills, posters and the views of current film historians, we aim to bring as much information to give a sense of just what we are missing.

In 1992 the BFI set out to define its Most Wanted missing films. Since that original campaign we have made many great re-discoveries. Our searches have taken us around the world and some films only survive with a variety of foreign sub-titles. We hope to continue this success, filling some more key gaps in the nation's collections.

To celebrate our 75th birthday, we'll be screening a series of recent discoveries, including **Michael Powell**'s ***His Lordship***, an off-the-wall musical featuring a plumber who is really a Lord, and ***The Constant Nymph*** (1928), the hugely successful adaptation of Margaret Kennedy's bestseller starring **Ivor Novello,** now on film for the first time since its original release.

In a special event on **Saturday 10 July**, Nathalie Morris (Curator of Special Collections) and Jo Botting (Curator, Fiction Film, BFI National Archive) will explore some of our missing cinema heritage using surviving fragments, rare stills and other materials from the BFI's collections. The curators will look at why films go missing and the problems found films can present.

ALBERTO CAVALCANTI

Alberto Cavalcanti is a much-travelled, genre-crossing genius, who has perhaps not enjoyed the critical attention he fully deserves. **July** at BFI Southbank sees an overdue celebration of his filmmaking, presented by film critic and historian **Geoff Brown**, who will give an introduction to Cavalcanti's career to launch the season.

The season focuses mainly on Cavalcanti's work in Britain and includes two major new restorations from the BFI National Archive of key works: ***They Made Me a Fugitive*** (1947), accomplished with funding from the Film Foundation; and ***Went the Day Well?*** (1942) in a national cinema re-release.

Brazilian by birth, Cavalcanti began in films as a French modernist, then introduced cosmopolitan panache to British documentary and Ealing Studios. He remains one of cinema's most idiosyncratic figures.

Born in 1897 to an aristocratic family, he followed architectural studies in Geneva with life in Paris, vortex of modern art. By the mid 1920s he was directing French avant garde films. Commercial talkies followed. Feeling boxed in, Cav (to use his industry nickname) crossed the Channel to work with the GPO Film Unit established by John Grierson, and later, Michael Balcon's Ealing Studios. For 15 years in Britain, Cav directed, produced, taught and inspired, widening the artistic horizons of an often parochial industry. With dwindling success, he went on to work in Brazil, Austria, East Germany, Italy and France again: a one-man travelling circus. He died in Paris in 1982.

Doing justice to this complex and multifaceted figure isn't easy. From the modernist poetry of ***Rien que les heures*** to the 'Brit-grit' thriller ***They Made Me a Fugitive***, the films he directed jostle through realism, surrealism and fantasy, and never settle on a single genre. Britain generated the best from him partly because he was the outsider, the foreign observer viewing us afresh. Working for Government agencies in peace and war, he never accepted patriotic bromides, nor did he worship the word documentary: it smelled, he said, of 'dust and boredom'. At Ealing, he sharpened the studio's vision of England in ways that his boss Balcon sometimes found uncomfortable.

A classic example is the hedonism of the wartime musical ***Champagne Charlie***, or the subversive sting of ***Went the Day Well?***, which shows just what happens when an English village is suddenly forced to confront takeover by Nazis disguised as Englishmen. Unexpected reserves of pride and determination inspire the local population to fight back against both collaborators and the enemy in a film which offers a compelling mix of whimsy and a brutal pragmatism.

Cav possessed precious filmmaking genius, but he lacked political *savoir faire*; hence in part his disjointed career, the dead-ends, the frustrations. This tribute season collects the best, the most personal, of his films; there are no others in cinema quite like them.

SUPPORT THE BFI

Film restoration and preservation is a hugely time-consuming and expensive activity. In July, the BFI will launch a nationwide fundraising drive to save films in need of restoration.

Curators at the BFI National Archive have selected a collection of films in desperate need of restoration. We will seek to rescue nine of **Alfred Hitchcock**'s early silent films, starting with his debut feature film ***The Pleasure Garden*** (1925) and ***The Farmer's Wife*** (1928), based on a hugely popular play by Eden Philpotts.

Full details of how to **RESCUE** or **ADOPT A FILM** will be announced in July.

BILL MORRISON AT DURHAM CATHEDRAL

Acclaimed artist and film director **Bill Morrison**, best known for ***Decasia*** (2002), will present a tapestry of archive films celebrating the coal-mining and musical heritage of the North East, with many of the film drawn from the BFI National Archive. The film – ***The Miners' Hymns*** – will be set to a specially commissioned score by Icelandic composer **Jóhann Jóhannsson** for 20 musicians.

The event takes place on **15 and 16 July** and has been specially commissioned for **BRASS: Durham International Festival 2010**.

MORE HIGHLIGHTS:

- At **BFI Southbank**, an exhibition entitled **75 Years of the BFI National Archive** will explore the Archive's history through 75 objects, revealing the fascinating stories behind some of its treasures. 1 July – 22 August. We are also planning a number of outdoor screenings, a Film Funday for families and some surprises still to be confirmed.

- **BFI Mediatheques** at BFI Southbank, BFI National Library, QUAD Derby, Cambridge Central Library, Wrexham Library and the Discovery Museum, Newcastle will have their collection of over 1800 items from our archive increased with a selection of recent re-discoveries.

- **New Online Resources** – the BFI website will launch a the **BFI Most Wanted** project in July, where members of the public can view stills, clips, reviews, posters, scripts or other items of evidence which can help to give a sense of a lost film. Additionally www.screenonline.org.uk, our on-line educational resource, will carry additional contextual information about the project with special materials suitable for schools relating to previous re-discoveries.

- Regular archive strands at **Projecting the Archive**, **The Flipside** and **Capital Tales** will also be featuring even more archival treats including ***A Night in Victorian London*** with silent film curator, Bryony Dixon. Listings in notes to editors

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NOTES TO EDITORS:

Screening in the *Dangerous Beauty* season in July:
The Yearling (USA 1946) dir Clarence Brown
In post-Civil War Florida, a boy learns a hard lesson when his pet fawn destroys his father's crops. Starring Gregory Peck and Jane Wyman in luscious Technicolor, it scored Oscars for both cinematography and art direction. **Mon 5 July**

The Private Life of Henry VIII (UK 1933) dir Alexander Korda
This Oscar-winning biopic of the much-married King has a career-defining performance from Charles Laughton in the title role. **Mon 19 July**

Fugitive Lady [La strada buia] (Italy-UK 1950) dir Sidney Salkow, Marino Girolami.
This *noir* story of an investigation into the apparent suicide of a woman's husband boasts wonderful low-key cinematography – seen to great effect in this virtually mint release print – from a young Tonino Delli Colli, who went on to shoot for Pasolini, Fellini and Leone. **Sat 17 July**

Brighton Rock (UK 1947) dir John Boulting
This British gangster classic was adapted by Graham Greene from his own novel. Attenborough is stunning as a 'ruthless, hollow-eyed psychopath' in charge of a race-track gang. Brighton's tawdry charms were memorably captured on location.
Mon 26 July

Further titles screening in August include:

Anchors Aweigh (US 1945) dir George Sidney
Gene Kelly, Frank Sinatra, the recently deceased Kathryn Grayson and Jerry Mouse star in this part-animated Technicolor MGM musical classic.

Volga-Volga (USSR 1938) dir Grigori Aleksandrov
Soviet musical comedy centred around a group of amateur performers on their way to a talent contest in Moscow – allegedly Stalin's favourite film.

Screening in the *BFI MOST WANTED* season in July:
His Lordship (UK 1932) dir Michael Powell
This off-the-wall musical features a plumber who is really a Lord, enamoured of a woman with Communist leanings but pursued by an American star who wants a title. Bizarrely, it works, thanks to lively performances, witty songs and a good line in dance numbers. Plus *Smith* (UK 1939, 9 mins), a recently discovered charity appeal directed by Powell. **Sat 24 July**

Bella Donna (*UK 1934*) dir Robert Milton
To his friends' dismay, naïve young Englishman Nigel Armine (Stuart) ties the knot with notorious *femme fatale* Mona Chepstow (a luminous Mary Ellis). But her plans to inherit Armine's wealth come unstuck when they move to Egypt, where Mona is seduced by a local, played by a magnetic Conrad Veidt. Astonishingly suggestive for a British film of the period. [With Czech subtitles] **Fri 23 July**

Secret Lives (UK 1937) dir Edmond T Gréville
Brigitte Horney was well-known on German stage and screen when she made this spy thriller in Britain opposite Hollywood star Neil Hamilton. Her luscious looks and outrageously high cheekbones are well-suited to the role of a German woman recruited to spy for the French. [With German and French subtitles] **Tue 27 July**

Lord Babs (UK 1932) dir Walter Forde
In this knockabout comedy musical set onboard a ship, recently titled Lord Drayford (Bobby Howes) finds himself engaged to the daughter of a pork-pie magnate and feigns regression to babyhood to avoid marriage. Alfred Drayton excels as the nouveau riche pork butcher. **Thurs 8 July**

Bed and Breakfast (UK 1930) dir Walter Forde
A partner-swap comedy in which an unlikely assortment of characters congregate in a country house where confusion runs rife. Adapted from a play, it was spiced up by a young Sidney Gilliat, cutting his teeth in British film. An early sound film, it was nonetheless praised on release as an amusing romp with excellent performances. **Fri 16 July**

Further titles in August will include:

Missing Believed Wiped Special: Terry-Thomas
Armchair Theatre: Lord Arthur Saville's Crime (ITV 1960) dir Alan Cooke
British comedy stalwarts, Terry-Thomas and Arthur Lowe, appear in this *Armchair Theatre* adaptation of Oscar Wilde's satirical short story. Although the first two reels were known to survive, the hitherto missing last third of the play was only rediscovered by our Archive a few years back. This is its first public outing as a complete piece.
+ Comedy Playhouse: The Old Campaigner (BBC 1967) dir Robin Nash
Terry-Thomas is a scheming philanderer determined to enjoy some extra-marital fun in Gay Paree. Discovered in the collection of a film buff, this was one of the fruits of the first year of Missing Believed Wiped.

Ultus Resurrected (UK 1916-17) dir George Pearson
A famously lost series of adventure serials recreated using extracts and other visuals. Presented by Judith McLaren.

The Constant Nymph (1928) dir Adrian Brunel
In a new 35mm blow-up from 16mm print. Hugely successful adaptation of Margaret Kennedy's bestseller starring Ivor Novello.

Emil and the Detectives (1935) dir Milton Rosmer
A newly acquired print of this much-loved adaptation of Erich Kästner's classic book for children. One of the young stars, Robert Rietty (now aged 87), will be invited to the screening as one of the highlights of Movie Magic in August.

Helen of Four Gates (1921) dir Cecil Hepworth
Newly acquired print of a melodrama of love lost and found in the Yorkshire Dales.

What Next? (1928) dir Walter Forde
Newly acquired print of this early comedy in which a salesman buys an old candlestick not realising its value and a mad collector pursues him.

Alberto Cavalcanti screenings throughout July:
Rien que les heures (France 1926) dir Alberto Cavalcanti
'No more than a series of impressions on time passing', but Cavalcanti's jagged picture of lowerclass Paris is constantly stimulating as it leaps between the realist gaze and modernist tricks in pursuit of a prostitute, a sailor and other characters in the City of Light.
Plus Marseilles melodrama ***En rade*** (1928), and the lyrical comedy short ***La P'tite Lilie*** (1927).

Au Pays du scalp (France 1931) dir Marquis de Wavrin
Celebrating Cavalcanti the surrealist, cultural explorer, and cinema magician. In 1931 he shaped a film from exquisite and bizarre footage of Amazon jungle tribes, taken by a Belgian explorer. Expect startling shots of shrunken heads, and adventurous music by Maurice Jaubert. Plus three key GPO Film Unit films: the classic *Coal Face* (1935, 12min); ***Pett and Pott*** (1934) – surrealism hits British suburbia – and Len Lye's intoxicating ***Rainbow Dance*** (1937).

Champagne Charlie (UK 1944) dir Alberto Cavalcanti
Champagne, ale, stacks of pork pies: pinstripe Britain and wartime rationing don't exist in Cavalcanti's musical delight about rival Victorian music-hall performers. The stars radiate personality; the period songs twinkle; lively details leap from Wilkie Cooper's deep-focus shots and Michael Relph's superb sets. Underneath, Cav the subversive stands up for liberty, fraternity and intoxication.
Plus Len Lye's exuberantly imaginative ***N or NW*** (1938).

Dead of Night (UK 1945) dirs Alberto Cavalcanti, Robert Hamer, Charles Crichton & Basil Dearden
Few pieces of British cinema chill and disturb like ***The Ventriloquist's Dummy***,
Cavalcanti's main contribution to Ealing's compendium of supernatural stories. Michael Redgrave, nervously tortured, is the ventriloquist hounded by his malignant dummy: a starkly told tale with expressionist trimmings (cheekily, Cav once called it a love story). Look out too for his ***Christmas Story***, small and suggestive, and
Hamer's dark critique of a complacent marriage, ***The Haunted Mirror***.

The Life and Adventures of Nicholas Nickleby (UK 1946) dir Alberto Cavalcanti
Cavalcanti and Dickens: an imperfect mix, though the authentic Dickens spirit can still be found in the film's breathless kaleidoscope of villainous grotesques, Victorian sentiment and whimsy. Bond is upstanding as the virtuous hero fighting to save loved ones from his uncle's clutches. But it's the passing parade, so vividly portrayed, that matters most. Hardwicke prompts shivers as the villainous uncle; Stanley Holloway spreads lovely warmth, and Sally Ann Howes smiles.

They Made Me a Fugitive (UK 1947) dir Alberto Cavalcanti
NEW RESTORATION BY BFI NATIONAL ARCHIVE WITH FUNDING PROVIDED BY THE FILM FOUNDATION
One character describes Griffith Jones' vicious black marketeer as 'cheap, rotten, after-the-war trash'. Delicate critics thought likewise about this gripping film. Post-war malaise hangs like a fog over its underworld drama, centred on Trevor Howard, seedy and rasping, as the Dartmoor escapee framed for murder and bent on revenge. Even now it's a dangerous cocktail of harsh violence, surreal black comedy, Hitchcockian twists, amorality, and French-style poetic realism.

For Them That Trespass (UK 1948) dir Alberto Cavalcanti.
This rare and fascinating thriller is made in the quizzical, poetic-realist style that became Cavalcanti's trademark. Stephen Murray launches the plot as the middle-class writer, slumming for his art, who conceals evidence about a
murder. But the film's unusually tender heart lies with Todd and Plunkett,
touching as London downbeats fighting against the odds for love and justice.

O Canto do Mar [The Song of the Sea] (Brazil 1954) dir Alberto Cavalcanti
Returning to Brazil, Cavalcanti energised the local film industry, though this powerful drama's poetic brand of social realism didn't win universal favour. In the drought stricken north-east, we follow a migrant family's fortunes in a port city
where mother love stifles and the only routes of escape are prostitution or the
sea. Cardoso's wonderful as the mother, while Cav observes the place and
culture with clear eyes, at a lyrical pace.

Went the Day Well? (UK 1942) dir Alberto Cavalcanti
NEW RESTORATION BY BFI NATIONAL ARCHIVE: RELEASED NATIONWIDE JULY 2010
Cavalcanti's wartime film, based on a story by Graham Greene, still unsettles, even shocks, with its subversive, almost surreal spectacle of a cosy English village under Nazi attack in the Second World War. Disguised as British soldiers, the invading Germans insinuate themselves into a pretty village inhabited by British character players so familiar to wartime audiences that they must have seemed like family members. Always the mischievous foreign observer, Cavalcanti kicks away their usual charm, letting them kill and be killed in a violent battle for their green, pleasant land. Critics' reactions at the time were mixed; but now we can properly relish this visionary film, as jolting and quizzical about British life as anything by Powell and Pressburger.

BFI National Archive
The BFI National Archive was founded in 1935 and has grown to become the largest collection of film and television in the world with over 180,000 films and 750,000 television programmes. With specialist storage facilities in Warwickshire and Hertfordshire the archive also boasts significant collections of stills, posters and designs along with original scripts, pressbooks and related ephemera. We are funded partly by OfCom as the official archive for ITV, Channel Four and Channel Five. We record a representative sample of television across Britain's terrestrial channels and are the official archive of moving image records of Parliament.

BFI Mediatheques
Anyone can get access to collections of over 1800 titles from the archive for free at BFI Mediatheques around the UK, currently at BFI Southbank, BFI National Library, QUAD Derby, Central Library Cambridge and Wrexham Library, shortly to be joined by the newest addition in June which will be in the Discovery Museum, Newcastle-upon-Tyne.

BFI National Archive Online
Our YouTube channel **BFIFilms** has over 300 items which can be viewed online. [Over 750,000 views have been recorded for *Alice in Wonderland* (1903) recently uploaded to coincide with the release of Tim Burton's *Alice in Wonderland*]. Academic access for higher education is through the **BFI InView** project. Schools and educational institutions have access to a wide range of material at **screenonline.org.uk**. This is in addition to paid access at the BFI for other research needs.

BFI Special Collections
12,000 prints a year are loaned out by the BFI National Archive to support the programmes of 800 venues across the UK and overseas and our DVD label regularly issues selected items. These have included the hugely popular British Transport Films Collection series, the legendary documentaries of The GPO Film Unit and most recently, highlights from the collections of the Central Office of Information.